success. However, its relationship with civil intelligence agencies was not close and productive.

Intelligence Bureau

Similar to the relationship between the UK's MI5 and MI6 or the US' FBI and CIA, the Intelligence Bureau (IB), the national civil intelligence agency of Pakistan, faced a turf war with a powerful internal rival, the ISI. In the realm of counter-terrorism, it was held back to play a secondary role, much below its capacity and capability.

Nevertheless, the IB's potential and prowess to play an effective role in countering terrorism could be gauged from the fact that the IB delivered whenever the government tasked it to tackle insurgency or terrorism. One of its mentionable achievements was the successful operation to counter the urban terrorism of MQM in Karachi in 1993–5. It accepted the challenge when the army had failed to tackle this situation. Violence in Karachi was at its peak at that time. A total of 30–45 bullet-ridden mutilated bodies were found in gunny bags daily.

People of Karachi were terrified. It seemed that the situation was irreversible. However, Benazir Bhutto, the then Prime Minister of Pakistan, while speaking at a public gathering at the border city of Kasur, Punjab, announced to control the situation. She tasked the Interior Minister Major General Naseerullah Babar and the IB chief Masood Sharif Khan Khattak to tackle the situation in Karachi. All of them went out and an ideal coordination of the IB and dedicated force of police resulted in bridling the situation within three to six months.

Similarly, in 2004–5, the IB played an effective role against Al Qaeda in urban areas of Punjab. It captured wanted Al Qaeda leaders like Ahmed Khalfan Ghailani and Naeem Noor Khan and foiled a number of terror plans. In KP, it operated against the TTP and linked militants and, at times, carried out excellent operations in 2006–7. The IB could perform during this period because it had a strong IB chief, Brig(r) Ijaz Shah, who was close to General Pervez Musharraf and therefore it managed to ward off the pressure and opposition of military agencies to some extent.

From 2013, during the regime of Nawaz Sharif, ample resources were provided to the IB to reorganise itself and to step up its counter-terrorism efforts. It managed to improve its performance and pulled off successes in the realm of counter-terrorism.